Rehman-ir-Rahim', as he physically ran his hands in reverence over the lines of the Quranic pages. In a Kayasth family of feudal landlords in UP's Fatehpur, the origin myth of this syncretic tradition went back to the legend of a Muslim peer[9] (Sufi saint) who apparently came down to their forebears seven generations ago. The family story was that the peer advised their ancestor to keep a Quran in the house, read it daily in secret, but to remain Hindu and not convert. That tradition had survived to the present day.

In a town that once had Muslim overlords, the practice may have begun as a social defence mechanism. The fakir story may simply have been an 'invented tradition'. Yet, it was also a fascinating story of secret and multiple selves, of a remarkable cross-pollination of religious traditions born out of centuries of co-existence and an outstanding example of the legendary Ganga–Jamuna tehzeeb of UP, a fusion of Hindu and Islamic traditions born out of centuries of co-existence. The Kayasths mastered Persian, then Urdu, as scribes and close associates of various Muslim rulers or landed gentry. They were far from an orthodox, closeted elite. This was not really multiculturalism in the modern sense. The original impulse may have been a survival instinct in a time of conflict, but the tradition had survived.

My new relatives in Fatehpur, I noticed, were more religiously 'Hindu' than anyone I knew, but still greeted each other with the Urdu 'salaam', not the Hindi 'namaste'. The black-and-white photos of their ancestors on the walls depicted two kinds of cultural layering. There were colonial-era photos of impassive-looking feudal nobility dressed in starched suits and British uniforms. But the oldest family portrait, preceding the British era, depicted a gentleman in the dress of Muslim aristocracy, with a beard and headgear in the Islamicate style. They had retained their Hinduness in the internal domain, but their external cultural selves had changed with the ruling zeitgeists. Now they were changing again.

The befuddling result of this syncretism was that the same family was involved in both Ram Temple kar-seva as well as a daily reading of the Quran. They had contributed ₹40,000 to the construction of the new Ram Temple after Prime Minister Modi led the consecration ceremony in Ayodhya. Yet, they had continued, till